

MALWARE INFECTION HANDLING PROTOCOL

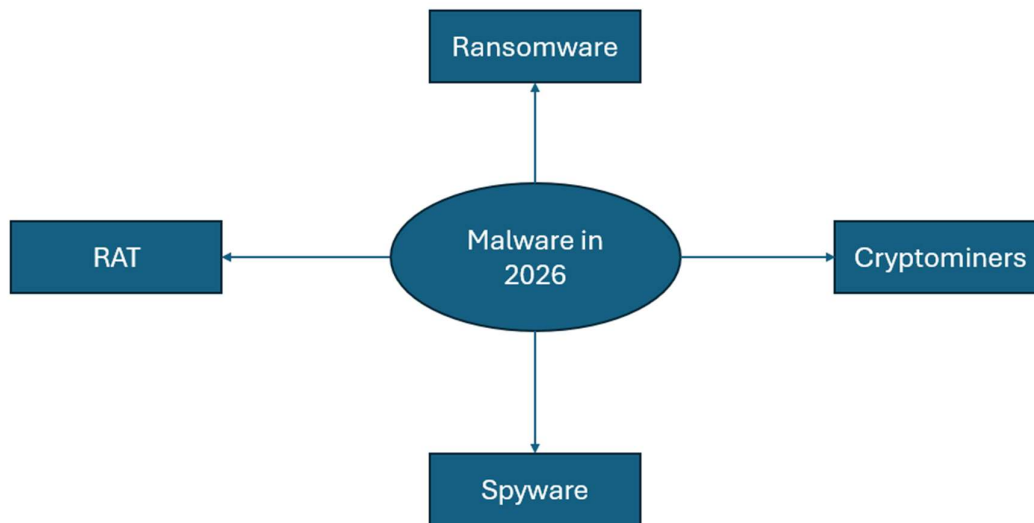
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Introduction

The malware infection handling protocol is designed to aid users and companies in removing malware in the case that malware has managed to infiltrate your device. This protocol was developed as sometimes malware can bypass defences meant to prevent it from infiltrating systems. This malware infection protocol will be mainly for Windows Operating systems. However, there will also be an example of Linux for those who may be on Linux operating systems. There are currently 5 main types of malware used by attackers in 2026. These include Ransomware, RATs (Remote Access Trojans), Spyware, Cryptominers and Loaders (Used to deliver other types of malware).

This malware infection handling protocol may not always be able to remove malware successfully from a device. This is because sometimes more sophisticated malware can avoid AV detection or infect firmware-level processes of the device. However, this protocol can heavily reduce and provide preparedness if malware were to infiltrate your device. Do not blindly trust this protocol as your only way to detect and remove malware. Make sure to adapt this protocol to the types of malware your threat model normally uses.



The spider diagram above shows the 4 most common types of malware used by attackers in 2026. This spider diagram does not include nation-state level malware. It also excludes loaders as they are used for delivering malware instead of causing direct harm to devices or data. Look at the paragraph above for more details on loaders and do your own research.

Main Malware Infection Handling Protocol

This section is specifically made for most cases of malware infection on systems. This section does not include any nation-state level specific protections or removal of malware. Make sure to adapt this protocol to your own devices and own threat model as each threat model uses different types of malware.

- **The first step in this protocol is to calm down**
- **This can be done by taking a few deep breaths or quickly releasing anger in a non-harmful way**
- **This step is important to reduce emotional noise, and it allows for more focus in removing malware.**
- **The second step is to establish a performance baseline for your device**
- **This step means having known verified baseline for how your device performs when Idle**
- **This baseline includes CPU usage, Disk activity, Network usage and RAM usage**
- **This can be done by using task manager on Windows or On Linux, you can use commands such as htop or Glances.**
- **This step can be skipped if you have already established a baseline**
- **This step is important to be able to detect malware as malware usually impacts the performance of your device or system.**
- **The third step is detection**
- **This means you will be detecting the malware on your device**
- **This can be done by noticing signs like for example slower performance or a malicious task in task scheduler**
- **You can cross-reference the current device performance against the baseline by closing all applications and non-essential processes.**
- **This step is important to confirm the presence of malware and prevent false positives at times**
- **The fourth step is containment**
- **This step means containing the spread of the malware**
- **This can be done by disconnecting the device from the network and changing passwords of accounts connected to the PC.**
- **This step is important because it reduces the blast radius heavily**
- **The fifth step is removal**
- **This step means removing the malware which can be done by using AV**
- **For example, you may use Windows Defender full scan or custom scan if you know where the malware is exactly located.**
- **This step is important to make sure that the malware is no longer affecting your device**
- **The final step is documenting**
- **This can be done through the structure What (Type of malware) → How (How did it access your device) → Patch(How did you remove it) → Improvements**

Malware Removal Failure Section

This section is specifically made for the case where malware removal is not successful. Sometimes more sophisticated malware usually seen in organised cybercriminals or nation-state threat models. This section cannot always provide a zero-budget or easy recovery process if the removal of malware were to fail. Make sure to adapt the steps in this section depending on your resources and threat models.

- The first step is to calm down once again
- This is because unsuccessful malware removal can be quite stressful
- This step can be done with deep breaths or releasing anger in a non-harmful way if needed.
- The second step is advanced removal
- This is because sometimes malware can be in the Firmware or Kernel processes of the device
- This step can be done through Windows Defender's offline scan or using Linux-supported AV such as ClamAV or Sophos Anti-Virus
- The third step is recovery
- This means restoring the data or operating system on the device via the usage of backups
- This can be done through clean installation of the operating system via USB or full system backups
- Other data like files and folders can be downloaded from cloud storage or physical drives
- The final step is documentation
- This means documenting the process of the more advanced removal and recovery.
- This can be done through the structure What (What was the malware?) → How (How did you remove the malware?) → Recovery (What was done for recovery?) → Improvements (What could be improved for next time?)



The spider diagram above shows the steps of the malware removal failure section. This does not include the order of the steps. Look above for the order of the steps.